

The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter



Photograph: AFP via Getty Images

Israel carried out more attacks on Hizbullah, an Iran-backed militia, in Beirut, **Lebanon's capital**. The bombings follow drone strikes on Israeli troops in southern Lebanon. Donald Trump urged Israel to carry out a more “surgical” attack on Hizbullah, saying he wants Lebanese to have a “better life”. Iran had earlier warned that an attack on Beirut would ignite a war across the Middle East.

Ukraine said Russian drones struck a nuclear-fuel storage facility within the Chernobyl exclusion zone. The UN's atomic watchdog called the attack “completely unacceptable”. The strike on the facility, located around 14km from the Chernobyl plant, site of a disaster 40 years ago, occurred a few days after Russia blamed Ukraine for a separate drone attack on the Russian-controlled Zaporizhia nuclear plant in south-east Ukraine.

Meanwhile **Russia** accused Ukraine of launching an “unprecedented” attack on St Petersburg. The Kremlin said more than 140 drones were shot down in the region surrounding Russia's second-largest city. Volodymyr Zelensky, Ukraine's president, defended the strikes as a response to Russian aggression. On Sunday Ukraine's president will travel to London to [discuss the war](#) with his counterparts from Britain, France and Germany.

Britain's deputy prime minister, **David Lammy**, said he spoke to **J.D. Vance**, America's vice-president, to challenge comments he had made about the fatal stabbing of [Henry Nowak](#), a white student. Mr Vance had blamed the teenager's death on a "mass invasion of migrants", adding to recent tensions between the allies. Mr Lammy said that he and Mr Vance remain "colleagues and friends".

The board of **Banco BPM**, Italy's third-largest bank, approved a proposal to open merger discussions with a domestic rival, **Monte dei Paschi di Siena**. Banco BPM said a tie-up would create a "national champion" with a market value of more than €50bn (\$58bn). The deal would continue the consolidation of Italy's fragmented banking sector. Last year MPS acquired Mediobanca for €17bn.

Mastercard and Visa are among the foreign companies fleeing **Cuba** as America [deepens sanctions](#) on the island. The payments giants suspended transactions for non-American visitors on Saturday while Spanish hotel giants, Iberostar and Meliá, said they are pulling out of managing at least a dozen Cuban hotels each. Last month Sherritt International, a Canadian mining company, said it had suspended operations in Cuba.

Iran accused **America** of denying visas for "integral" members of its team ahead of the World Cup. The White House has said that visas have been granted for Iran's footballers and "necessary support staff". But Iranian state media claimed that 15 officials, including the head of the football federation, have been denied entry. Iran is due to play three games in America.

Word of the week: *Paz Total*, Gustavo Petro's failed policy to engage with all of Colombia's rebel groups at once. The outgoing leftist president's successor may [choose to break with it](#).



Photograph: Reuters

Armenia is breaking free of Russia's grip

On Sunday Armenia holds parliamentary elections. The vote will rile Russia, once the country's closest ally, as polls suggest that Nikol Pashinyan, the Western-leaning prime minister, will probably win. Since Armenia lost a war with Azerbaijan in 2023, Mr Pashinyan has reshaped his foreign policy. With [support from America](#), he is making peace with Azerbaijan. He wants to normalise relations with Turkey, another historical foe, and strengthen ties with the European Union.

A motley group of pro-Russian, nationalist opposition parties want to reverse this [pivot to the West](#), but their support is thin. Russia's leaders are furious. They have banned many Armenian imports and threatened to cut gas supplies if Mr Pashinyan is re-elected. Dmitry Medvedev, a former president turned Kremlin loudmouth, has warned that Mr Pashinyan is following "the dangerous path" of Leon Trotsky (who was murdered by a Soviet assassin for his opposition to Stalin). If Armenians needed evidence that Russia is an unreliable partner, the Kremlin is providing it in spades.



Photograph: AP

Peru's unenviable choice

On Sunday, Peruvians will choose between right-wing Keiko Fujimori or leftist Roberto Sánchez as their next president. Neither is particularly popular, and both come with authoritarian baggage. Ms Fujimori promises to tackle crime by governing in the style of her father, an autocrat who was convicted of ordering kidnappings and extrajudicial killings. Mr Sánchez, meanwhile, wants to pardon [Pedro Castillo](#), a former president imprisoned for an attempt to stay in power through a coup in 2022.

In a last-ditch attempt to win over centrists, Mr Sánchez has abandoned some of his more radical economic proposals. An Ipsos poll published on Thursday showed him pulling ahead of Ms Fujimori, hitherto the favourite to win, by 0.6 percentage points. A close vote could spell more political trouble. Ms Fujimori, who has lost the past three elections, blamed her last defeat in 2021 on fraud, despite a lack of evidence. Asked by a reporter from *La República*, a daily, this week if she would recognise the results this time, she responded: “we’ll see.”



Photograph: Getty Images

F1 gets fast and fashionable

The Monaco Grand Prix is the most glamorous race in the Formula 1 calendar. On Sunday drivers will swerve around the tight streets and hairpin bends of Monte Carlo, against a backdrop of superyachts bobbing on the Mediterranean Sea.

F1 works hard to cultivate a glitzy image. After the competition ended its long relationship with tobacco in 2006, when a ban came into effect, it faced a sponsorship hole. It has since courted banks, high-end booze and more recently crypto. Its newest partners include Disney and Lego, reflecting a growing interest among young fans.

Amid a broader increase in F1's global popularity, especially among women, luxury brands have taken a keener interest. Gucci, an Italian fashion house, will be the title sponsor of the Alpine team next season. LVMH, a French luxury giant, is said to have paid \$1bn for a ten-year "global" partnership deal. (This year's race winners will receive a commemorative Louis Vuitton "trophy trunk".) A [new sponsorship formula](#) seems finally to be working.



Photograph: AP

Everything's Coming Up Tonys

It will feel like Christmas for theatre kids of all ages on Sunday, when P!nk, a singer who has never appeared on Broadway, hosts the Tony Awards at Radio City Music Hall. Performers include Rachel Zegler (who will play Eva Perón in an upcoming revival of “Evita”, following a run in London), Leslie Odom junior, Queen Latifah, and the casts of several nominated musicals.

A revival of Arthur Miller’s “Death of a Salesman” is the most-nominated play, with nine. “The Lost Boys” and “Schmigadoon!” share that honour for musicals, with a dozen nominations each; prediction markets favour the latter for the main trophy. Nathan Lane (as Willy Loman) and John Lithgow (as a virulently antisemitic Roald Dahl in “Giant”) are the two leading best-actor contenders. Other likely winners include Lesley Manville, for her commanding performance in “Oedipus”, and André De Shields, who won his first Tony for Hadestown in 2019, for playing Old Deuteronomy in “CATS: The Jellicle Ball”.



Photograph: Getty Images

Alexander the Greatly entertaining

How do you measure the greatness of Alexander the Great? Perhaps by the size of the empire he conquered (it stretched 4,800 kilometres, from Athens to India). Or the speed with which he conquered it (about a decade). Or even the death-toll: some have estimated that almost 1% of the ancient world's population died as a result of his campaigns. However you cut it, he obsesses people. Almost 5,000 books have dissected him. The latest, out this week, is [“Alexander: God, King, Man”](#), by Edmund Richardson.

Unlike many other academics, Mr Richardson can tell a rollicking good story. He rollicks through Alexander's childhood (he tames an untameable horse); through his early battles (he conquers an unconquerable city); and of course his frolicking. Alexander's lovers included “360 of Darius's former concubines (one for each day of the Persian year) and a spectacularly handsome young Persian named Bagoas”. The book offers a lesson in how history can be both academically ambitious and readable.



Illustration: Sandra Navarro

The winners of this week's quiz

Thank you to everyone who took part in this week's quiz. The winners, chosen at random, were:

Kevin Osinski, Medina, Washington, America

Sandra Lindstrom, North Saanich, Canada

Jaeho Lee, Seoul, South Korea

They gave the correct answers of the Northwest passage, windows, birds, steps and Rebecca. The theme is films directed by Alfred Hitchcock: "North by Northwest", "Rear Window", "The Birds", "The 39 Steps" and "Rebecca".

The questions were:

Monday: The British ships *HMS Erebus* and *HMS Terror* were lost in 1845 in the attempt to navigate which waterway?

Tuesday: Casement, sash and bay are types of which architectural feature?

Wednesday: Which highly-common animal group is believed to have descended from dinosaurs?

Thursday: The recovery programme at Alcoholics Anonymous consists of 12 what?

Friday: Who in the Bible was Isaac's wife (and mother of Jacob and Esau)?

*Who looks outside dreams; who
looks inside awakes.*

Carl Jung